TACKLING TRASH

Experts highlight steps that India can take to address the environmental threat effectively

STRENGTHEN DATA COLLECTION

↘ The government must rigorously estimate production, consumption and recycling of plastic. Even today, several state pollution control boards do not provide data

REGULATE PRODUCTION

↘ Plastic production by petroleum and petrochemical companies needs to be regulated to effectively address the source of the problem

IMPROVE DISCLOSURES

↘ Those who are dealing in plastics should disclose, in their annual filings, the amount they have put out in the environment as well as collected, recycled and incinerated

ECOFRIENDLY PACKAGING

↘ Packaging should prioritise end-of-life design, promote reusable models and restrict composite plastics due to their high cost and recycling challenges

PROPER LABELLING

↘ Every plastic product needs to be labelled according to its type and recyclability to ensure proper waste segregation, recycling and disposal

RAISE ENFORCEMENT

↘ Enhancing the capacities of officials at various levels is essential to ensure effective implementation and enforcement of plastic waste management policies

GOVT CAMPAIGNS

↘ Government can lead behaviour change campaigns to encourage individuals and communities to embrace sustainable practices and reduce reliance on single-use plastics

informality in the collection and disposal system. "Almost 30 per cent of the plastic waste is incinerated, which is included in plastic recycling figures. This should not be the case," says Satish Sinha, associate director, Toxics Link. Experts also lament the lack of authentic data in the country.

RECYCLING RIGMAROLE

Not all plastics are the same, and each kind has to be recycled separately. India's problem is that segregation at the source or household level remains poor. So, plastic becomes part of mixed solid waste—dumped with wet waste like vegetable and fruit peels, and dry waste like paper, plastic bags and e-waste. Also, even though thermoplastics such as polypropylene, polystyrene and low-density polyethylene are recyclable, they are often treated similarly to the non-recyclable thermoset plastics, and sent to waste-to-energy plants.

Most waste collection in India also happens via informal channels such as kabadiwalas, who pick up only the waste that is lucrative. So, while 'easy' plastic waste like PET bottles, shampoo and bodywash containers fetch up to Rs 40-50 for a kg, other types of plastic—such as multilayer and disposable boxes—fetch only Rs 5-10 per kg, and are often left uncollected, according to Sinha of Toxics Link.

Plastic products have also become very complex, says Vinod Kumar, programme officer, waste & sustainability, Toxics Link. "Different polymers are being compressed or mixed together to make products, making their recycling extremely difficult and expensive." Unrecycled items often get dumped in landfills or purchased by brick kiln owners, albeit illegally, to generate heat for firing the bricks. "In rural areas, households often resort to burning garbage for disposal or generating heat during winters due to weak waste collection systems, releasing toxic fumes in the environment," he says.

In the absence of high-grade recycling and contamination of plastic waste, most plastics are downcycled—essentially used to make low-quality household items like buckets, jugs and synthetic clothes. Because of this, they can only be recycled 3-4 times in their lifetime, says Abhishek Deshpande, co-founder & COO of Recykal, a tech solution provider that helps manage the plastic waste of 12,000-plus businesses.

Until the collection and recovery of plastics in a closed-loop manner becomes a reality, the narrative must shift towards reduction, says Rodrigues. Change, Sambyal suggests, must begin at an individual level. Like always carrying a cloth bag and saying no to shopping bags. Also, developing a habit of keeping three items in one's bag: basic steel cutlery, including a steel or coconut straw, a water bottle, and a bag for eating out at roadside kiosks. "This way, you'll end up avoiding a lot of single-use items. Once you're able to practise it daily, try to influence at least five people around you to do the same to create a chain of multipliers," she says.

Given the colossal scale of the crisis, global action is imperative. In 2022, 175 UN member-countries agreed to create a first-of-its-kind legally binding treaty to curb plastic pollution. However, its release was postponed during the negotiations last year in Busan, Korea, due to differences over a variety of issues, among them capping plastic production, which saw strong opposition from oil and petrochemical-producing countries. The next negotiations are scheduled to take place from August 5-14 in Geneva. The needle has to move fast, as plastic will outweigh fish by 2050 and may even exceed the biomass of all humans on the planet. ■